

HC HANDBOOK

#multimedia

Analyze or craft communications with layered modalities.

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Defining the HC

Pitch

Synergizing media rule! Interfering media drool!

Paragraph Description

Multimedia works incorporate several communication modalities in order to convey meaning. Visual, aural, spoken, and written modalities may be combined in different ways, and each combination conveys a message differently. To draw inferences about and create multimedia communication, one must understand how these different modalities complement, undermine, or intensify each other.

Categorization

Foundational Concept | Multimodal Communications | Using Nonverbal Communication

Cornerstone Introduction

Class: Multimodal Communication | Semester Two

Unit: Multimedia



Big Question: How is technology changing communication?

General Example

You are watching television, and a commercial begins with a scene of a family having fun at a well-lit party while lively music plays in the background, setting a comfortable and fun atmosphere. The family's smiles make you comfortable due to the theory of emotional contagion, which describes a phenomenon where one individual's emotions have the ability of inducing the same emotional experience in others. The family leaves the party and gets in a car to drive home. A few seconds after the mother starts driving, the music suddenly turns ominous and the lights in the scene dim. You feel your heart-rate increase as you start getting unsettled due to the sudden change in environment, and realize that the darkness makes it hard to see exactly what is going on. The music stops as the screen turns black and you can hear the sound of a crash and screams. Sorrowful music plays, and the scene is now of an upturned car surrounded by debris. The scene changes again, showing the mother drinking beer with other adults earlier at the party. Red, bold text appears that says, "Think about your family. Don't drive under the influence." and the text fades in the silence. You are impressed by how the commercial manages to synchronize lighting and music choice, as well as utilize visual and contextual information to convey different moods: a calm one at first and a tragic one at the end.

Footnote: *The commercial effectively combines different types of media to create different moods, including a more festive, happy mood (through using well-lit environments with light-hearted music and the visual of a smiling family) and a more ominous, tragic mood (with less light, sorrowful music, and sound effects alluding to an accident). Additionally, the lack of music with the bold text also works to create an impact on the audience, highlighting the message being transmitted.*

** Is it this HC?**

Is #multimedia the right HC? If the answer to the following questions is yes, #multimedia could be useful:

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1. Are you blending multiple mediums together to illustrate your message?
2. Would incorporating another medium elevate your work product?
3. Are you attempting to communicate a message that is hard to squish into a single medium?

Consult the following table listing possible related HCs.

The following HC might apply if the work:	
#medium	analyzes and utilizes elements of a single medium at the level of form and structure.
#persuasion	- discusses the design and execution of an argument. - considers different theories and effects at play, like the assimilation effect from social judgment theory.
#context	situates a work in its appropriate context for analysis or argumentation.
#communicationdesign	uses principles of communication design to connect with the intended audience.
#emergentproperties	explains how the interactions between multiple parts of a complex system give rise to an emergent property.

Self Study

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Try answering the questions on your own before checking the example answers.

👉 What are the differences between the terms *medium*, *medium element*, and *multimedia*?

👉 How can you break a multimedia analysis into a step-by-step process?

👉 What are some key multimedia techniques used in film to keep an eye out for?

👉 When critiquing #multimedia, what details should you pay attention to?

👉 How can one use #multimedia to create a sense of unity?

👉 How can one use #multimedia to create contrast?

💡 Applying the HC

Guided Reflection

- Does the application create or critique a work that employs multiple different media?
- Does the application utilize different media to create a holistic deeper meaning?
 - Alternatively: do the different media in the piece conflict with each other in a way that undermines an intended deeper meaning?

- Is the use of multimedia described and explained clearly?
- Does the application mention how the different media conflict or complement each other?

Common Pitfalls

- The application lays claim to multimedia when only one medium was used or analyzed.
- The application uses different media, but the multimedia result is disjointed or confusing.
- The application describes a multimedia work but fails to explain how the different media interact—whether they complement, contrast, or even conflict—and why.
- The application only completes part of the analysis—either describing medium choices without interpreting them, or analyzing one medium without addressing others.
- The application assumes the media work well together without analyzing or explaining how they do.

Applying the HC at Minerva

Anytime you are creating multimedia work, this HC will help you connect with your audience and portray your main ideas.

Communication is all around us all the time, and it rarely takes the form of a single medium. By utilizing multimedia, you can bring your message to life.

Some examples of applications include:

- You make a short film to convince people to support San Francisco's street artists. In this film, you capture how you feel in the presence of street art by filming many clips of you interacting with street artists around the city. When editing these clips together, you get creative with the sound levels, colors, and transitions between clips. To create a contrast between how the audience feels between scenes with and without street art you make some deliberate choices. In scenes without street art, you lower the saturation of the clips, dulling the colors. You also increase the decibels of the ambient noise, making the city sound busy and anxious. Finally, you decide not to include transitions so that one scene merges with the next without inherent flow. On the other hand, in scenes featuring street art, you up the saturation of visuals, decrease ambient noise, and use transitions

to create a smooth and natural change from one clip to the next. At the end of the short film, you present a written call to action that says: support street artists, they bring our cities to life. Since the short film does not feature writing before this point, this phrase catches the audience's attention and clearly states your goal.

- You have determined a new medicine helps reduce inflammation in joints with tendonitis, however, you expect most doctors will not understand how it works and why it is a better option than traditional tendonitis treatments without a clear explanation. Therefore, you create an animation of the medicine, using multimedia principles to ensure the animation is as informative as possible. You ensure the colors of the animation add to the viewer's understanding of the medicinal process by deliberately illustrating the pill and its anti-inflammatory growth factor contents in a bright green color because green symbolizes health and stands out from the rest of the animation. You also include informative background noise. At first, the sound in the background is dissonant because the tendonitis is present and causing pain. Then upbeat sound effects are used to simulate the sound of the pill contents dispersing throughout the bloodstream, attaching to the inflamed tissue. Finally, the background sound turns melodic as the pill increases growth and soothes affected tissues, effectively ridding the patient of tendonitis. You use this animation to pitch your medicine to doctors who then prescribe it to patients.

Applying the HC Outside of Minerva

- You realize you suddenly feel on edge and anticipate something bad is going to happen in the thriller you are watching with friends. The visual scene has not changed, however, you expect the feeling to be a product of the film's effective multimedia communication. So, you listen closely and realize the background music has changed to an ominous chord in b minor and is slowly getting louder, cultivating your uneasiness.
- You make a TikTok video to promote your small business by utilizing transitions that keep viewers engaged, using both audio and text to share your message, and placing trending audio behind your narration to get further reach. This careful

combination of multimedia elements work together to get a larger reach than usual, and your orders increase dramatically.

Key Resources

- Minerva Academic Team. (2021). HC Guide for Visuals.
<https://my.minerva.edu/academics/hc-resources/additional-resources/>
 - Check this out as an additional resource for successful application of #multimedia and other HCs related to visual communication.
- Ignite. (2021, March 3). How to analyse a film - cinematic techniques. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=c-LPwanZv9A>
 - This resource explains how to analyze film by highlighting the basic language with which to analyze films. Note how the different film techniques surveyed in the video fall under the subcategories of #medium (literary, visual, musical).
- RocketJump Film School. (2016). Cuts & Transitions 101 [YouTube Video]. In YouTube.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OAHoMoAv2CI>
 - Check out this resource for a closer look at different types of cuts and transitions used in multimedia works.
- Now You See It. (2015). How Film Scores Play with Our Brains. In YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bCpYbSz1KqE>
 - This video highlights how film scores create interesting multimedia effects.

This page was last updated on 06/02/2025 15:58